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Newsom Visits Israel, Pledges $10 Million for Police Patrols at Synagogues, Mosques

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Gov. Gavin Newsom visited Israel on Friday after pledging $10 million in state funds to increase law enforcement presence at synagogues and mosques because of the war started by Hamas.

"Amid the horror unfolding in the Middle East following the unconscionable terrorist attacks in Israel, California is authorizing the immediate deployment of funds to increase security and police presence at places of worship across the state," Newsom said on Thursday before his flight. "No matter how and where one prays, every Californian deserves to be safe."

The state will reimburse local governments for the costs associated with the increased patrols. In addition to the law enforcement funding, the state will grant $20 million to nonprofit organizations to improve their physical security.

In the past two weeks, both the House of Israel in Balboa Park and the Islamic Center of San Diego in Clairemont have been vandalized.

The Governor's announcement was praised by representatives of both the Jewish and Muslim communities in California.

"These critical security resources will make a huge difference and send a powerful message when so many in our community are feeling on edge," said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel and Sen. Scott Wiener, co-chairs of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus. "California cannot stand idly by while the Jewish community or any other vulnerable community is threatened by hate and extremism."

"We welcome Governor Newsom's proactive measures to protect Californians," said Hussam Ayloush, CEO of the Council on American-Islamic Relations California. "California Muslims are increasingly anxious as we observe dangerous rhetoric that continues to dehumanize Palestinians and Muslims, and which leads to a rise in anti-Muslim incidents targeting students, employees, and everyday Muslims in their homes or on the street. Everyone deserves to be safe."

Few details of Newsom's itinerary in Israel were released, but he said he planned to meet some of those people affected by the war.

"Thank you Governor of California," said Israeli President Isaac Herzog, "for your visit of solidarity to Israel. We will never forget our friends who stood by Israel in our most difficult times."

After the visit, Newsom issued a statement praising the Israeli spirit amid the tragic events.

"I grieved with families in mourning, I met with young soldiers fresh from bomb shelters and battlefields, and I sat with leaders who bear the responsibility of response to it all," Newsom said.

"Despite the horror, what I saw and heard from the people of Israel was a profound sense of resilience," he said. "That's the Israeli spirit. And it's also the California spirit."

The Governor's day-long visit to Israel is a stop on an longer economic-development and climate-action mission to China.

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